



century, their society had collapsed and split into small groups that were easily overpowered by the Spanish a few centuries later. The people did, however, keep control of both their land and their cultural heritage, both of

which have survived into the 21st century. Today, there are over 30 Mayan groups in Central America, mainly in southern Mexico. Some of them even speak a version of the ancient Mayan language.

COMING HOME

Typical Mayan houses are made of locally available materials like wattle and daub (rubble and clay), plaster, and wood. They are usually painted white. In areas with heavy rainfall, homes have palm- or grass-thatched roofs that are steeply pitched, with overhanging eaves to protect the walls. The small plot of land this cottage stands on is enclosed by a stone wall and a length of rush fencing.

The front door has a coat of fresh blue-and-white paint.



Woven checks are a popular choice.

FANCY FEMALES

These days, Mayan men and boys tend to wear plain Western clothing, while women's dress reflects decorative historical elements such as bold borders and colorful embroidery. This barefoot mother-and-daughter pair have chosen traditional skirts and blouses in bright cotton fabrics.



MAYAN MUSIC

The modern marimba, similar to the xylophone, is part of the Mayan musical tradition. Originating from a primitive instrument brought to Central America by early African slaves, it was adopted and developed by the indigenous Mayan people.



HAPPY NEW YEAR

Mayan culture sets great store by New Year. This Guatemalan group is holding a mountainside ceremony to wash away the past and prepare for the year ahead. Mountains have special meaning for the Maya, who believe they house protective spirits.



WINTER FESTIVAL

The people of Chichicastenango, Guatemala, commemorate the arrival of the white man in a ceremonial Dance of the Conquistadors, part of their annual winter-solstice festival. This costumed participant wears the mask of Tecum Uman, last Mayan emperor of Guatemala.

FIRED EARTH

The entire Mexican village of Amatenango is dominated by its famous women potters. Using the local *terra-cotta* clay, and passing on skills from mother to daughter, these Mayan women have been producing decorative pots and bowls here for centuries.

Terra-cotta means fired earth.

